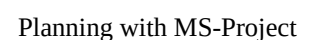


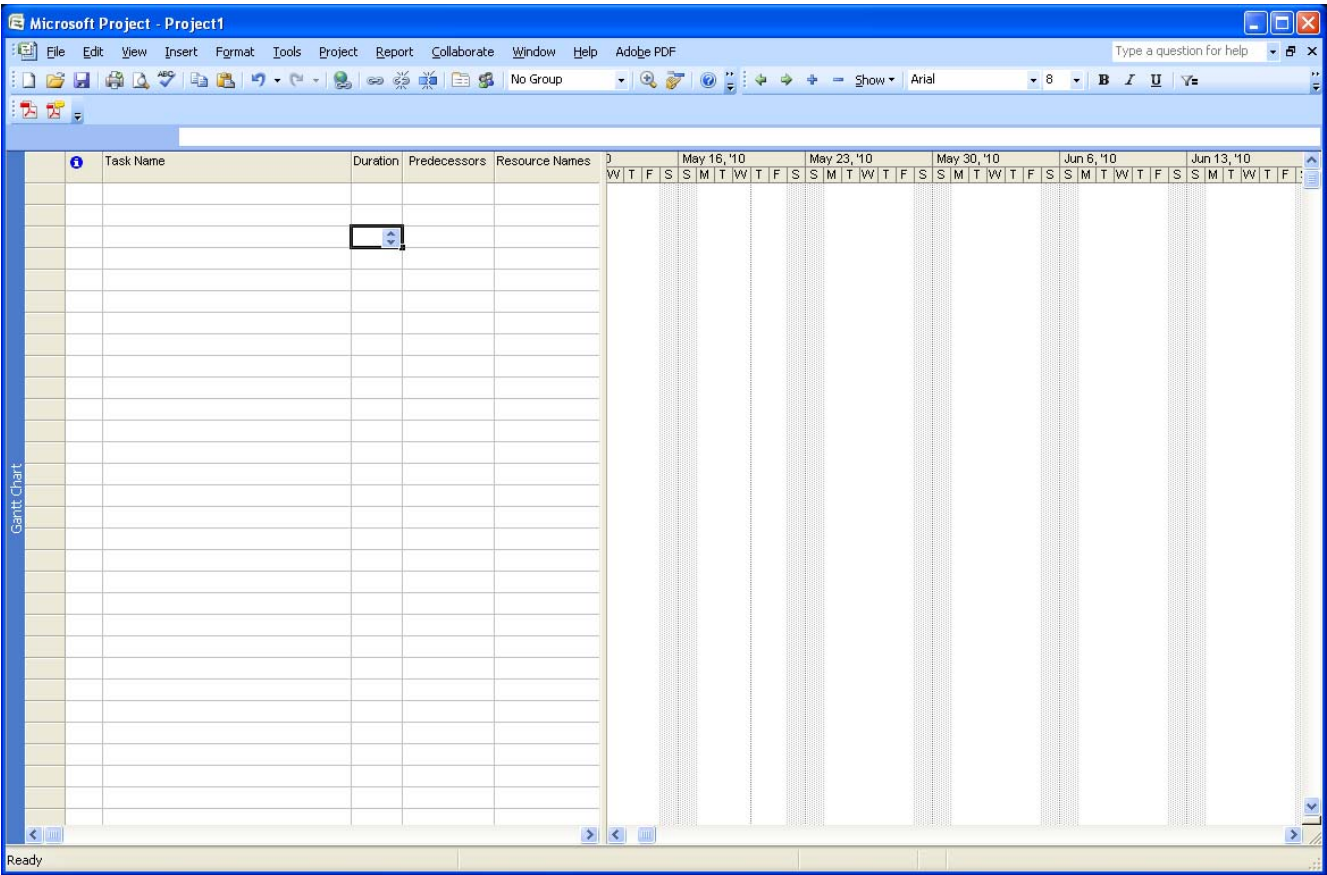
Part 1: Preliminary set-up

After you install the product and launch it, you'll see this screen:



most of which you'll never need for planning and controlling a single project. Fortunately, they're alphabetized, so you can find and select **Predecessors**.

What's still missing? The estimated *quantities* of the specified resources and the *task deliverables* specification. We don't have a simple way of entering that information on the above form, so for now we'll leave the form like this:

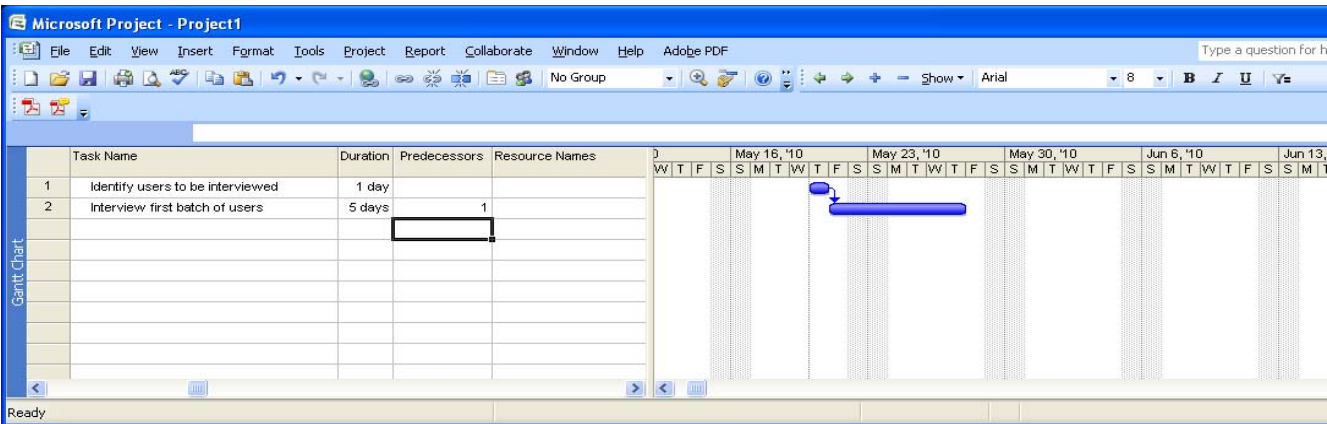


You'll want to adjust the widths of the columns, but that's easy to do at any time.

Note that there's also no *task identifier* column. *MS-Project* will assign them automatically in the form of sequential numbers. The tasks will get renumbered from time to time as the plan evolves, so the identifiers have no permanent significance and shouldn't be referred to in other documents.

Entering a project plan

Now we can start to enter a project plan. Let's enter a couple of tasks:



Whoops! MS-Project is assigning definite start and end dates to our tasks. But we're just preparing a plan and don't yet know when (or if) the project will actually begin. We just want the Gantt chart to show time relative to the project start. Erase the tasks and right-click the row containing the dates. That opens a menu from which we select Timescale, which in turn brings up a dialog box:

Timescale

Top Tier | **Middle Tier** | Bottom Tier | Non-working time

Middle tier formatting

Units: Weeks | Label: Jan 27, '02 | ☒ Use fiscal year

Count: 1 | Align: Left | ☒ Tick lines

Timescale options

Show: Two tiers (Middle, Bottom) | Size: 100 % | ☒ Scale separator

Preview

May 16, '10							May 23, '10							May 30, '10							Jun 6, '10							Jun 13				
T	F	S	S	M	T	W	T	F	S	S	M	T	W	T	F	S	S	M	T	W	T	F	S	S	M	T	W	T	F	S	S	M

Help OK Cancel

Look over the long list of **Label** options, just dozens of ways of displaying time. (*MS-Project* is sometimes criticized for paying more attention to formatting and display than to actual project planning and control.) **Week1, Week2. . .(from start)** seems appropriate. Now our data-entry form looks like this:

Microsoft Project - Project1

File Edit View Insert Format Tools Project Report Collaborate Window Help Adobe PDF

Type a question for help

No Group

Task Name Duration Predecessors Resource Names

W T F S S M T W T F S S M T W T F S S M T W T F S S M T W T F S S M T W T F S S M T W T F S

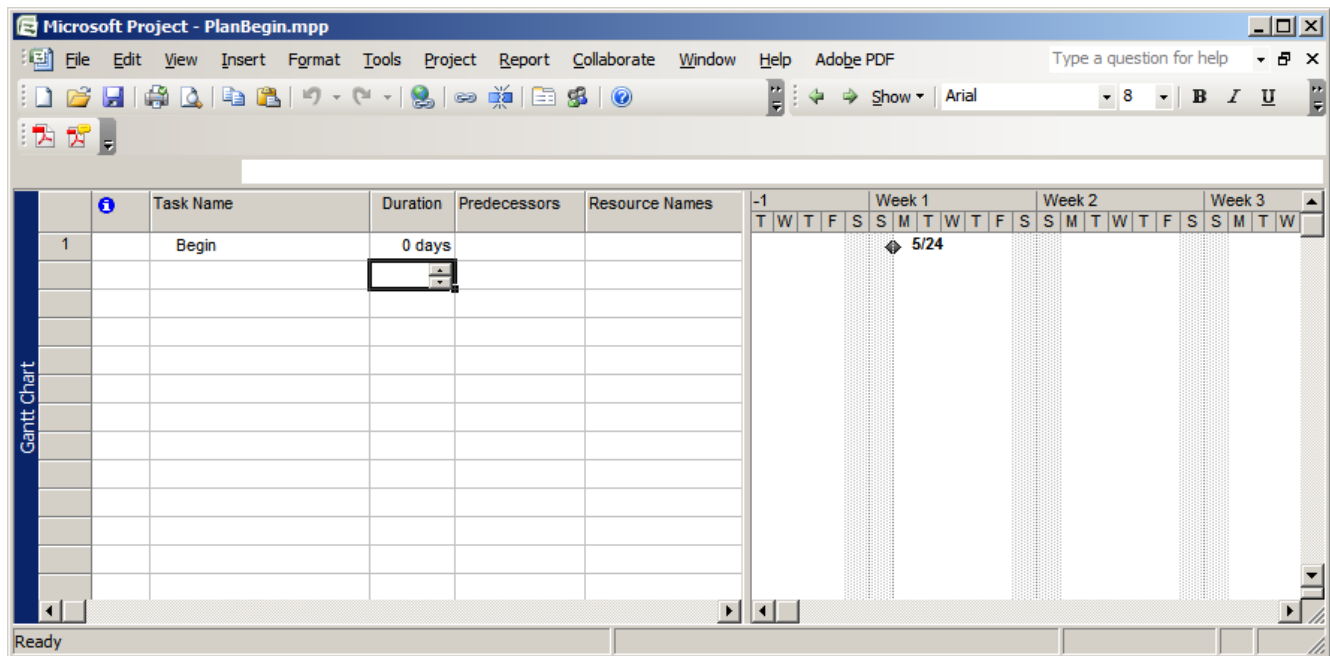
Week -1 Week 1 Week 2 Week 3 Week 4

Gantt Chart

Ready

Are we now ready to start entering tasks on our plan? No, there's still a problem. Although the Gantt chart will *display* dates relative to the start of the project, *MS-Project* will still assign specific dates internally! We need to do one more thing: On the first line, enter a dummy **Begin milestone**, a task with 0 duration. We'll specify **Begin** (task #1) as predecessor of every task that really has no predecessor. Then when we know the actual date on which the project will start, we can enter it as the start date for **Begin**, and the whole project plan will get adjusted to the actual calendar.

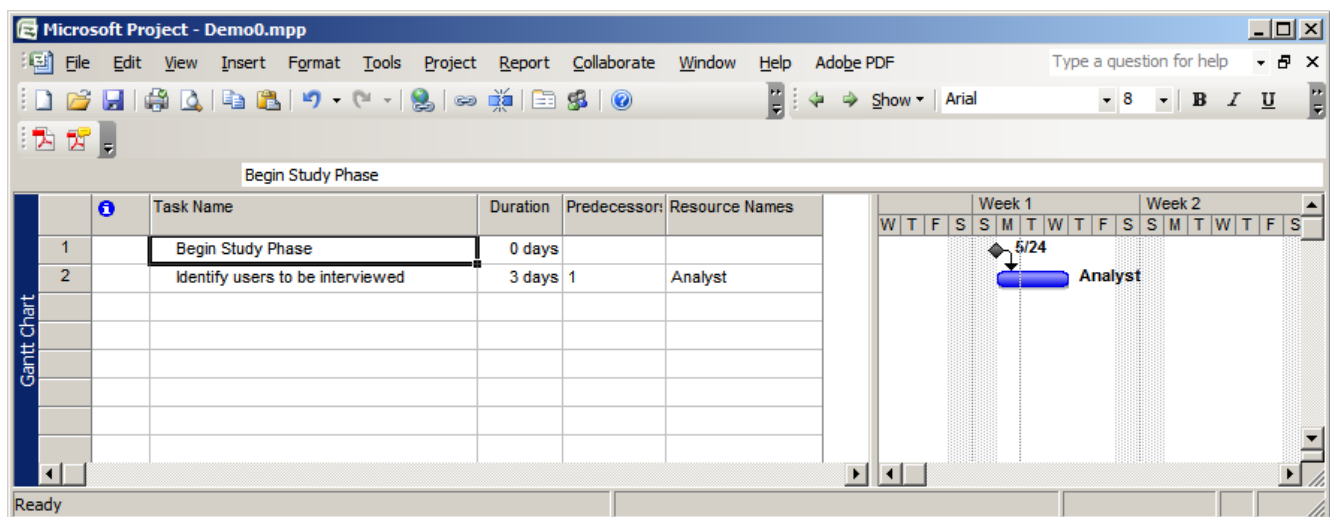
So here's the way the form should look before we start entering tasks:



Now we'll enter our project plan.

Specifying a task

Suppose we've just agreed to investigate the need and potential benefits of a new computer application system. The sponsoring user has authorized funds for a preliminary study phase. We know that we're going to have to interview people in the user organization to determine what they think they need. So we'll start by identifying those people:



Now there are still three essential things missing from the above task specification:

- Specification of the deliverable(s) to be produced.
- The quantity of the Analyst resource required
- Any contingencies

That information won't fit on this form, but we can easily enter it. Right click on the task name and select **Task Information** from the menu. You'll then see this:

The 'Task Information' dialog box is shown with the 'General' tab selected. The 'Name' field contains 'Identify users to be interviewed'. The 'Duration' is set to '3d' and 'Estimated' is unchecked. 'Percent complete' is at '0%'. The 'Priority' is '500'. The 'Start' date is 'Mon 5/24/10' and the 'Finish' date is 'Wed 5/26/10'. There are checkboxes for 'Hide task bar' and 'Roll up Gantt bar to summary', both of which are unchecked. At the bottom are 'Help', 'OK', and 'Cancel' buttons.

This **General** tab contains no useful information,¹ but the **Notes** and **Resources** tabs² will allow us to complete the task specification. Let's agree to specify the task deliverables³ in the Notes area:

The 'Task Information' dialog box is shown with the 'Notes' tab selected. The 'Name' field still contains 'Identify users to be interviewed'. The 'Duration' is '3d' and 'Estimated' is unchecked. The 'Notes' area has a toolbar with icons for text formatting and a rich text editor. The notes text reads: 'List of names, positions, and contact information for:

(Group 1) Managers who can explain aspects of the purpose, need, and potential benefits of a new system.

(Group 2) People who would routinely use such system in their jobs and who can explain the deficiencies and shortcomings of current practice.' At the bottom are 'Help', 'OK', and 'Cancel' buttons.

¹ In fact the dates are misleading

² For the sake of simplicity we won't try to use the **Custom Fields** facility, but you may want to investigate it for your projects.

³ In the list of field names under **Insert Column** you'll find several that refer to "deliverables", but they don't support simple specification of the results of a task. Under the Collaborate menu, you'll see **Manage Deliverables**, but that's concerned with communication among multiple projects, and it's unavailable in the standard version of MS-Project..

If there are contingencies to specify, we can put them in the Notes section, too. Finally, we need to quantify the resources. We've already specified that the task will be assign to an Analyst and we've estimate that he or she will need 3 days to compile the information, but we haven't specified how much of those 3 days will be spent on this task. Assuming normal delays waiting for phone calls or E-mail to be returned, it seems reasonable that the Analyst will spend about ¼ of his or her time on this task during those 3 days:

Task Information

General | Predecessors | **Resources** | Advanced | Notes | Custom Fields

Name: Identify users to be interviewed Duration: 12d ☐ Estimated

Resources:

Resource Name	Assignment Owner	Units	Cost
Analyst		25%	\$0.00

Help OK Cancel

Note that MS-Project has misunderstood our original **Duration** specification as a manpower estimate, altering the duration to 12 days! That's all right; just re-enter the correct duration:

Task Information

General | Predecessors | **Resources** | Advanced | Notes | Custom Fields

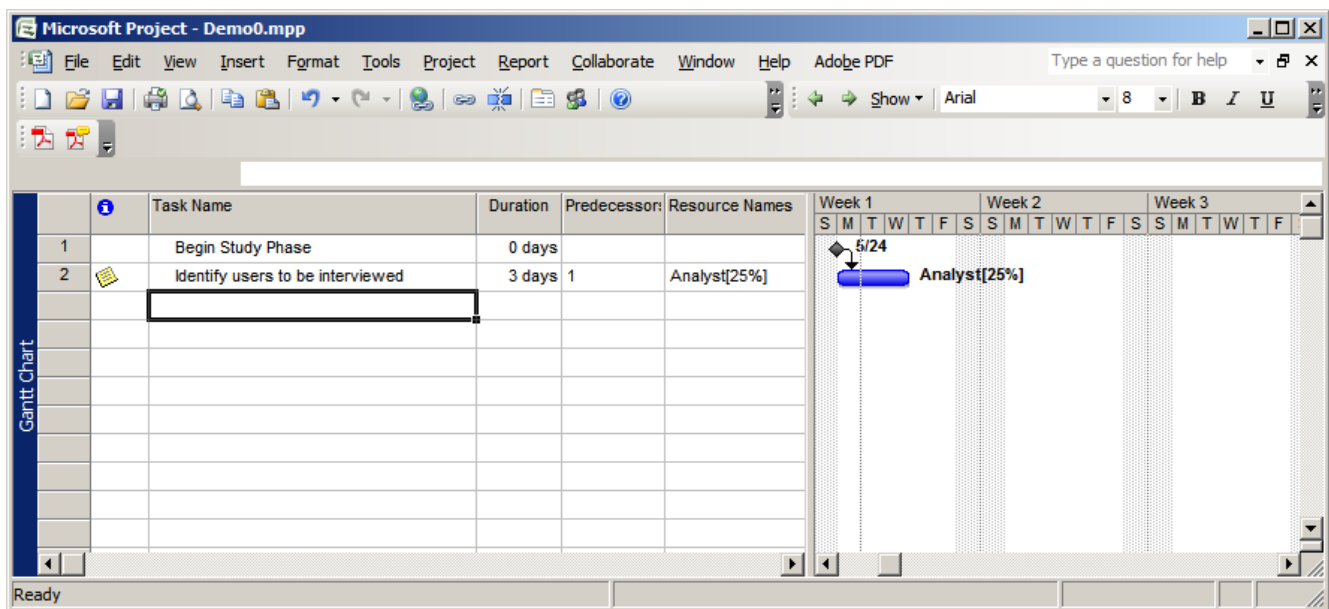
Name: Identify users to be interviewed Duration: 3d ☐ Estimated

Resources:

Resource Name	Assignment Owner	Units	Cost
Analyst		25%	\$0.00

Help OK Cancel

It may seem that we had to go to a huge amount of trouble to specify a simple task, but now that it's done the information is easy to see and easy to modify.



Note that the **Notes** field is now shown as an icon in the leftmost column, and we can quickly navigate to it by clicking the icon.

Now that we've set up MS-Project, in part 2 we'll enter our project plan.